

Red panda sidekick — first round of work

Before anything else, please click through the working prototype — [\[prototype link\]](#). It only takes a few minutes and it's the quickest way to get a feel for the app: when the panda appears, how often, and what it's doing for the person using it.

Four pieces of work to start with: the character itself, one hero pose, the breathing animation, and four feeling illustrations. Everything else in the app can wait until the character is settled.

PROJECT

Sidekick — an anxiety and panic support app

ANIMATION TOOL

Rive

CHARACTER REVIEW

Wednesday or Friday — tell me which suits you

SCREEN SIZE

Mobile, 390 × 844pt

What the app is

The user opens Sidekick when they are anxious, wound up, or mid-panic attack. The red panda is the whole interface: it greets them, it sits with them, it breathes with them, and it reacts when they log how a day went. Tone is warm, plain, a bit funny, never clinical and never saccharine.

The rough drawings shown throughout this brief are my own placeholder sketches. They show intent and composition only — please treat them as blocking, not style direction.

1 · Design the red panda and the anxiety ball monster

A red panda with a big head and a small body. The head carries all the expression, so it should stay large enough to read clearly at around 100px on screen.

The character must have its own style, clearly separate from Aggretsuko.

Alongside the panda there is a second character: the anxiety ball monster. It represents the anxiety itself — a dark, round mass that looms behind the panda when things are bad and shrinks as the user calms down. It should be unsettling but not frightening, and it should never look like something to be defeated. It gets smaller, it doesn't get beaten.

WHAT I'D LIKE TO SEE

- 2–3 style directions for the panda, front-on, neutral standing pose
- The anxiety ball monster in the same style, at a big size and a small one
- A quick note on the line weight and colours you've used, so we can check the character still reads clearly when it's shown small on a phone

We review these together on Wednesday or Friday and pick a direction before you go further.

2 · One pose for “Tap me when you need me”

This is the home screen. The panda sits in a card with a line of text underneath and a “Tap me when you need me” button below that. The card cycles through eight different panda-and-line pairings, one every few seconds.

We start with **one pose**. Once we've given that one a good to go, you take it up to three. Below are the eight lines that cycle on this screen with the placeholder sketch I used for each. Pick whichever line you'd most like to draw, and design the pose for that one.



01

“You're doing better than you think.”



02

“I get anxious too. We can get through this together.”



03

“Some days I feel like keeling over too. Let's just sit down.”



04

“Hiding is a valid plan. I'll be in here if you need me.”



05

“Doing nothing still counts. Ask me how I know.”



06

“Sometimes you just need to yell about it. I'll go first.”



07

“It never comes at a good time, does it. It still passes.”



08

“Nothing's wrong right now. Let it be boring.”

COMPOSITION CONSTRAINTS

- Square-ish framing, roughly 120 × 120px on screen
 - Panda centred, nothing important near the edges
 - The text sits below the drawing, so the pose needs to read without it
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3 · Breathing animation

A looping animation of the panda breathing, used during the guided breathing exercise. The user copies the panda, so:

- The movement must be **very visible** — followable without instruction, and readable out of the corner of an eye by someone mid-panic. Subtle is the one thing it can't be.
- Inflating and deflating, a glow that builds and fades with colour, or both — your call.
- I'll be pairing it with **haptic feedback**, so the phone buzzes along with the in-breath and out-breath. It needs clear, distinct beats for the haptics to land on.
- The prototype paces at **5 seconds in, 8 seconds out**, three cycles before the app checks in. Treat that as intent rather than fixed — I'll likely drive the timing in Rive, so build the loop with in and out stretchable independently.
- A furry anxiety monster sits besides the panda and shrinks as the breathing goes on. One idea if you want to bring it in: the panda up on its hind legs in shock, paws in the air, then sitting down to meditate while the monster grows smaller.

PLEASE SIT THROUGH THE WHOLE EXERCISE

Not just the first screen. The breathing loop keeps running underneath a sequence of screens where the panda explains what's happening in the body, offers affirmations, and asks the user to pick an option. The panda stays on screen the whole time, and the pacer never stops to let a screen talk.

1 • Breathing

3 cycles

“In through your nose” / “Out through your mouth”, with a countdown. Panda breathing, anxiety monster at full size.

2 • User picks

tap an option

“What's happening in your body?” — heart racing / can't get a full breath / feel like fainting / hands tingling. Pacer keeps going while they choose.

3 • Explanation

2 screens

Plain answer to whatever they picked, e.g. “Your heart is beating fast to move blood to your arms and legs.” Pacer continues, never pauses to explain.

4 • Affirmations

4 lines

“This feeling is horrible, but it can't hurt you.” → “Don't fight it.” → “It will pass on its own.” → “I'm still here.” Counting has stopped. No talking animation needed — the panda simply carries on with the breathing exercise.

5 • More lines

4 lines

“Every panic attack ends. This one is ending too.” Again the breathing continues underneath — same loop, nothing new to draw.

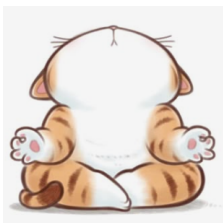
6 • Grounding

5 steps

“Feel your feet on the ground.” **This one needs a separate pose:** panda seated, paws flat on the floor, still, breathing slowly. Ends with “I feel better” or “It's getting worse”.

WHAT THAT MEANS FOR THE ANIMATION

- The breathing loop has to hold up for several minutes, across screen changes
- Stages 2 to 5 all run on the same breathing loop — no talking animation needed
- Grounding is the one exception: a separate seated, grounded pose, with a way into it from the breathing loop without a visible cut



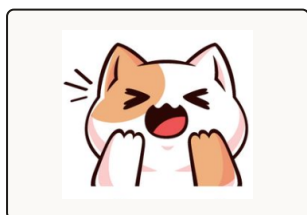
NOTES

- Sits inside a circle roughly 200px across, on a dark screen
- Calm and slow. No bounce, no comedy on this one.
- Needs a graceful entry and exit — it fades in mid-panic
- Rive file with the in-breath and out-breath as separate, timeable states

All the meditation illustrations here are just ideas. They need not be exactly the same — if you have something better, do that instead.

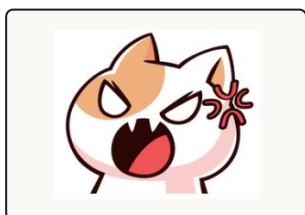
4 · Four feeling illustrations

On the “How are you feeling?” screen the user picks one of four states. Each needs its own panda illustration. They sit next to each other in a list, so they should feel like one set — same framing, same weight — while the emotion is unmistakable at a glance. Treat this as the expression sheet for the character: once these four work, we have the range.



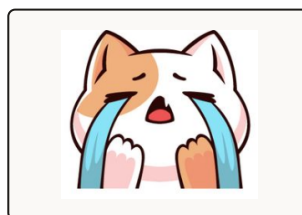
Can't cope right now

Overwhelmed, mid-panic. The largest of the four on screen — it's the primary action.



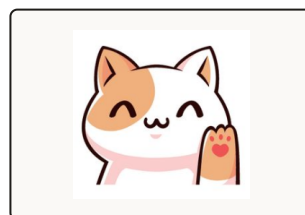
Wound up

Tense, irritable, fizzing. Cross rather than sad.



Low

Flat and heavy. Gentle, not tragic.



Actually okay

Settled and unbothered. Quietly pleased, not triumphant.

Sizes on screen: “Can't cope right now” shows at about 104px, the other three at about 58px in a row. Everything has to survive at 58px, so keep the detail count low.

Files and next step

- Stills: vector
- Animation: Rive
- Background is a warm off-white (#F4F2ED) on light screens and near-black (#1C1B20) on the panic and breathing screens — the character needs to read on both

Start with the character. Send the style directions across before we meet, and let me know whether Wednesday or Friday works better for the review.